

Envelope 04 · Rabi al-Thani · The Man Who Could Not Leave His Street

Style B3 – Big Shapes. Bricolage Grotesque and Newsreader. Every word read from source; every drawing from tools/envelope_art.py, which has no figure in it.

Still open where it shows: the fact panel is TO VERIFY and the return address is not set.

ENVELOPE – C5, 229 × 162 MM

NOOR POST

One of fourteen. Open it on the day.



FOR

[Child's name]



Noor Post

[Return address – not set]

INSIDE THE FLAP

ENVELOPE 04 • RABI AL-
THANI • INSIDE THE
FLAP

Open together.

🕒 About twenty-five
minutes

● is the grown-up. ○ is you.

- 1 The letter – read it out loud, ● and ○ taking turns
- 2 The hadith card
- 3 The prints
- 4 Open the case file
- 5 The stickers
- 6 The postcard

THE LETTER – ONE A4 SHEET FOLDED TO A5

FACT PANEL

Imam al-Hasan al-Askari

(peace be upon him)

B. 232 AH, MEDINA · D. 260 AH, SAMARRA

- **Where and when.** Samarra, a garrison city on the Tigris built by the Abbasids when Baghdad had had enough of their soldiers. Walls, barracks, a river. He lived almost his whole life inside it and is buried there.
- **Who was ruling.** The Abbasid caliphs, from Samarra itself – the throne changed hands several times in his short lifetime, and none of them let him go.
- **The imamate.** About six years, from 254 AH, from the age of about twenty-two. **The shortest of the fourteen.**
- **What he left.** Letters, and the network that carried them. His representatives are named in the sources – Uthman ibn Sa'id among them, who went on to be the first of the four who carried letters during the occultation. **The system outlived the man by seventy years.**
- **Nargis.** The mother of his son. In the accounts she reached that house from far outside the empire, and what happened in it was kept quiet from everyone including the household. *Traditionally told, the accounts of her origin vary.*
- **Elsewhere in the world.** In the same years, on the other edge of the known world, the first Norse settlers were arriving in Iceland – traditionally dated to 874 CE – to farm an island with no people on it.

He died in Samarra in 260 AH, aged about twenty-eight, under the watch he had lived his whole life under. Shia accounts hold that he was killed on the orders of the caliph al-Mu'tamid.

ENVELOPE 04 · RABI AL-THANI

The Man Who Could Not Leave His Street



• is the grown-up • ◦ is you • ◦◦ is together

• Samarra was not really a city. It was an army camp that had been built in a hurry and had got too big, sixty miles up the river from Baghdad, full of soldiers who had been brought in from somewhere else and did not speak the language of the people they were guarding.

◦ Why did he live there?

• Because he was not allowed to live anywhere else. His father had been moved there before him, and he grew up in it. That is where the family name comes from. Al-Askari means *of the camp*.

◦ Was he in a prison?

• No. That is what makes it interesting. He had a house, and a door, and he could walk down his own street. He just could not leave, and he could not teach in the open, and twice a week he had to present himself at the palace so the caliph's men could see him with their own eyes and write it down.

◦ Every week? For years?

• For years. Whatever else was happening, twice a week, there he was. They watched him arrive and they watched him go home.

THE MAN WHO COULD NOT LEAVE HIS STREET · CONTINUED

- Now here is the part nobody expects. While that was going on, there were people in Egypt sending him money. There were people in Iran asking him questions and getting answers back. There were places on the far edge of the empire, months of travelling away, that knew what he had said about something within the year.

| ○ How?

- That is what I want you to work out. Not guess – work out.

| ○ Is it a trick?

- No. It is a real question with a real answer, and the answer is in the envelope, sealed. Five things we know are on the cards. Every one of them is true and every one of them is a piece of it.

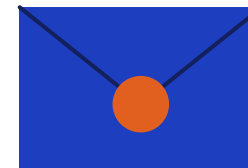
| ○ Say your first guess out loud before we look at the cards.

- Think about who is allowed to move around an empire without anyone finding it strange. Think about what a guard bothers to look at, and what a guard looks straight past.

SAY THIS ONE TOGETHER

•○

**How do you run a whole
community from one
street?**



Then the hadith card.

2

3

IMAM AL-ASKARI SAID

**“The heart of the foolish is in
his mouth and the mouth of
the wise is in his heart.”**

Imam al-Askari

NOOR POST · THE FOURTEEN

The chain

Every card in this box is one link. Lay all fourteen in order and the chain runs from the Prophet to the last of the twelve, each one passing on what was given.



Fourteen segments · historical order

Tuhaf al-Uqul, short maxims, no. 21. Translated by Badr Shahin,
Ansariyan Publications, Qum.



THE CASE FILE

The question

How do you run a community spread across a whole empire when you are not allowed to leave your street?

Five evidence cards. Read them in any order. Then say your answer out loud, before anyone opens the sealed card.



EVIDENCE

1

Twice a week he had to present himself at the caliph's court. He went. Everyone saw him arrive and everyone saw him leave, and it was written down.



EVIDENCE

2

Money reached him from places he had never been. Qom. Nishapur. Egypt. It arrived, and it was distributed, and records of it exist.



EVIDENCE

3

He wrote no long books. What survives is letters – short ones, each to one person, answering one question.



EVIDENCE

4

Many of the people who came to see him were merchants. Merchants crossed that empire constantly, in every direction, carrying goods and paperwork, and nobody thought it strange.



EVIDENCE

5

Some of the people carrying things for him were people the guards did not count as worth watching. An oil seller. A servant. A woman with a basket.



Sealed

Parent: open this only when the child has committed to an answer. Not before. Let them be wrong out loud first – being wrong out loud is the mechanism.



THE ANSWER

He did not do it himself. He built a network and then he stood still inside it.

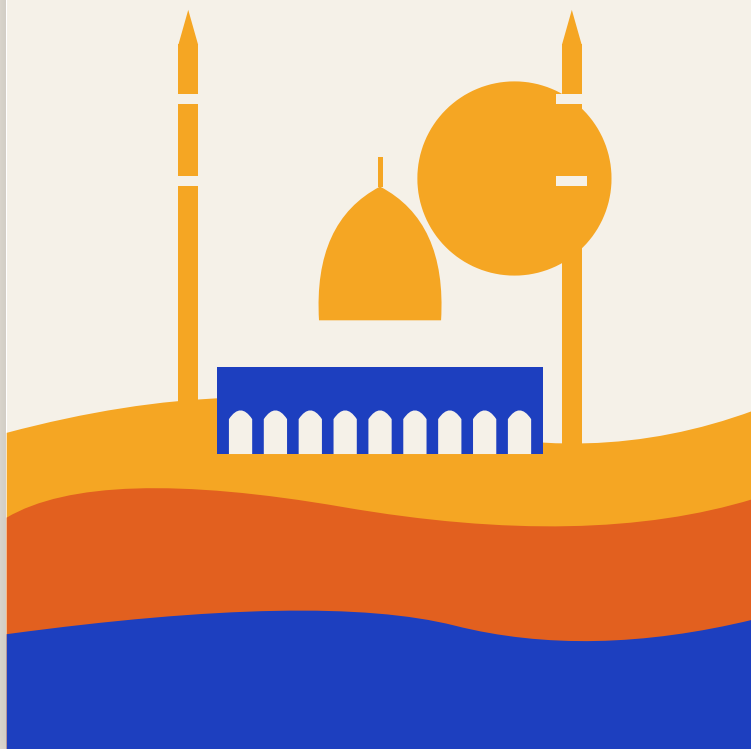
In every region there were trusted people – called *wakils*, meaning representatives – who collected money, passed on questions, carried answers back, and settled things locally that did not need him. He was one point in a system, not the system.

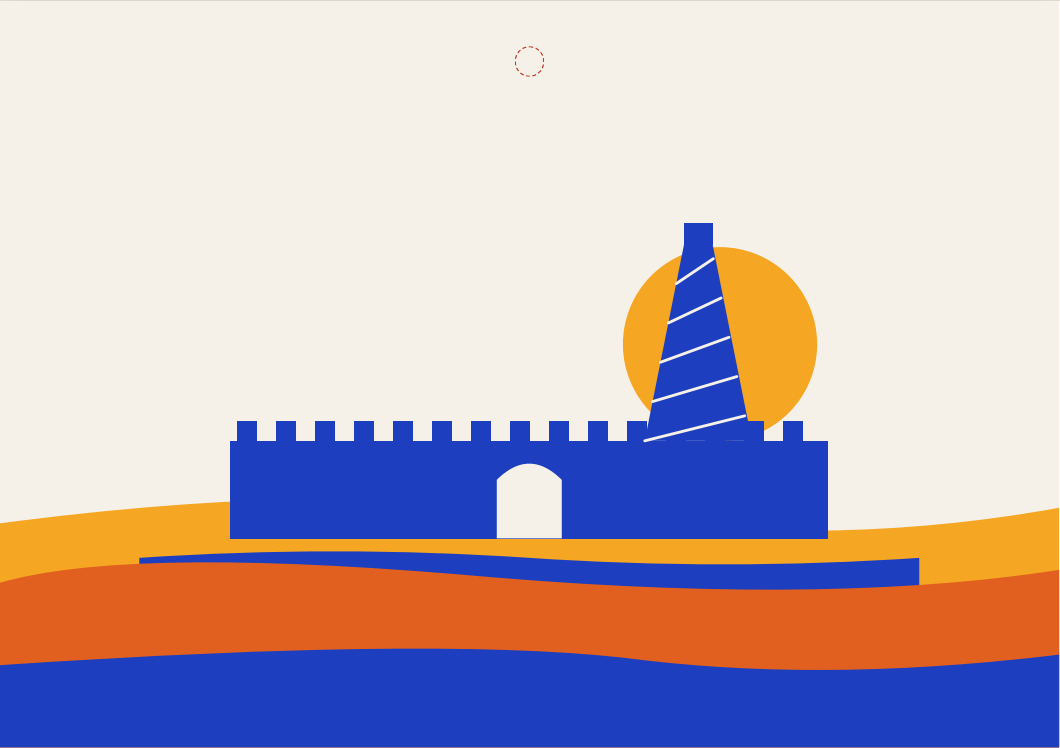
That is why the letters are short and why there are no long books. A short letter can be carried inside somebody's normal life. A long book has to be a journey of its own.

And it worked because the empire's own roads were already full. Trade went everywhere, all the time. He did not need his own messengers. He needed people who were already going.

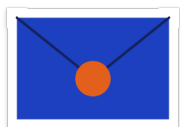
Being watched closely in one place is not the same as being watched everywhere. The men outside his door had one job, and they did it perfectly, and it was not enough.



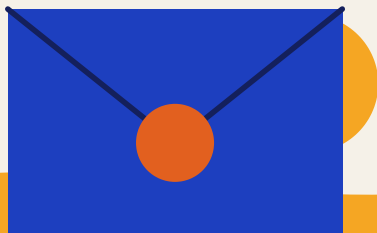




STICKER SHEET – A6, KISS-CUT



RETURN POSTCARD – A6 LANDSCAPE



**We opened this one
together.**

• _____

○ _____

Post it back to us, or keep it. Either is right.

STAMP

Noor Post

[Return address – not set]

